



Some p.m. rain 52/39 • Tomorrow: Sunshine 47/33 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 18, 2024 • \$3

Kyiv says it carried out killing of top general

Head of Russia’s nuclear defense dies in Moscow bombing, Ukraine claims

BY DAVID L. STERN, LEO SANDS, ROBYN DIXON AND ISABELLE KHURSHUDYAN

KYIV — A high-ranking Russian military official was killed Tuesday morning in Moscow when an explosive device attached to a scooter detonated as he exited a residential building — a brazen bombing claimed by Ukraine’s security service as both Kyiv and Moscow have intensified attacks ahead of potential peace talks.

Lt. Gen. Igor Kirillov, chief of Russia’s nuclear, biological and chemical defense forces, is the highest-ranking Russian military official to be killed outside combat since the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. The SBU, Ukraine’s domestic security service, was responsible for the “special operation,” according to an agency official who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the sensitive matter.

Though Ukraine’s security services have taken responsibility for bombings far behind enemy lines, Tuesday’s bombing raises questions about the security of even senior officials in Russia’s capital. Video of the explosion captured by someone waiting in a nearby parked car was widely circulated across social media within hours.

The timing also appeared purposeful. Just a day earlier, the SBU charged Kirillov in absentia

SEE RUSSIA ON A14

Igor Kirillov: Britain had previously placed him under sanctions. A15

THE TAKEOVER



DADO GALDIERI FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

In the Amazon, a violent invasion

As darkness descended upon the isolated village, two gunshots echoed in the still grasslands. Then, a longer burst: eight shots.

Alexandre Apolinário, a leader in this Indigenous territory, said he should have known what they meant. He’d seen the arrival of the gang, with its guns and thirst for gold. He’d watched it recruit villagers, turning his people against each other. He knew the extreme violence it had brought to neighboring Indigenous lands could one day come to his own.

But when the shooting finally began this September, Apolinário struggled to believe it. Dismissing the shots as errant hunting and reminding himself that his Macuxi people had experienced relative peace here,

Moving into the forest’s remote corners, a gang finds profit and power in environmental crime

BY TERRENCE MCCOY AND MARINA DIAS
IN BOQUEIRÃO INDIGENOUS TERRITORY, BRAZIL

Police perform a night raid in the Boqueirão Indigenous Territory in Brazil.

SEE BRAZIL ON A10

Apolinário finished his evening bath and sat down to rest inside his thatched roof hut.

When he opened his WhatsApp messages, he saw his optimism had been misplaced.

“There was an assassination attempt,” a community notice announced. A gunman had tried to kill an Indigenous boatman who was working with the government, then fled into the darkness. “Any outsider is a suspect.”

As the night deepened, it became clear that the attempted killing was almost certainly the work of the PCC, one of the world’s most sprawling and feared criminal organizations. In the last two decades, even as it received scant attention in the Northern Hemisphere, the Primeiro Comando da Capital — First Capital Command — has remade

Kingpin who fueled D.C.’s crack scourge dies in Fla.

BY KEITH L. ALEXANDER AND PAUL DUGGAN

Rayful Edmond III, a onetime drug kingpin who spent more of his life in prison than out of it for his role fueling the District’s murderous crack cocaine epidemic, died suddenly Tuesday within a year of his release date, according to a U.S. Bureau of Prisons official.

Edmond, who turned 60 in November, died at a facility similar to a halfway house in Florida, said bureau spokesperson Kristie Breshears. No cause of death has been released. Edmond had been moved this summer from a federal penitentiary to “community confinement” and was set to be released late next year, the agency has said.

Arrested in 1989 and initially sentenced to life in prison with no eligibility for parole, he became a government informant during his decades of incarceration, providing an “unparalleled magnitude ... of cooperation,” a judge wrote in 2021 in significantly reducing his sentence.

Once described by prosecutors as the “Babe Ruth of crack cocaine,” Edmond exuded a charisma that helped him command an army of dealers and build a mountain of profits.

He was convicted of federal drug-trafficking charges in D.C.

SEE EDMOND ON A19



CULLEN GRANZEN/REUTERS

Mourners pray Monday in Middleton, Wisconsin, after a classroom shooting killed two in Madison.

School shooter had rocky home life

BY SARAH BLASKEY, PATRICK MARLEY, HANNAH NATANSON AND REIS THEBAULT

MADISON, WIS. — The 15-year-old girl who killed two people and wounded six others at her small Christian school here Monday had a turbulent home life, according to court records, which show that her parents divorced and remarried multiple times and that she had been enrolled in therapy.

Natalie Rupnow, who also

Court records show she attended therapy amid parents’ frequent splits

went by Samantha, died of an apparent self-inflicted gunshot wound after police say she opened fire in a study hall classroom at Abundant Life Christian School.

The academy’s tight-knit community was still stunned Tues-

day, grieving the student and teacher who were killed and searching for answers to explain the latest act of violence to strike an American campus.

Police have released few details about Rupnow beyond her name, and they said they were investigating a possible motive behind the shooting. With much still unknown, a Washington Post review of court records points to an unsettled childhood for Rupnow, whose parents’ custody agreements sometimes forced

SEE SHOOTER ON A7

Conspiracy theories fly amid drone panic online

With trust in government and media low, sightings in N.J. lead to wild claims

BY TATUM HUNTER

NEW YORK — On TikTok, one video casts a recent string of mysterious drone sightings in New Jersey as an “invasion” “coming off the ocean” to target “sensitive infrastructure” like bridges and nuclear plants. On Facebook and X, posts say the sightings are evidence of an Iranian espionage operation or a U.S. military surveillance campaign.

None of the claims are substantiated, and state and federal officials are struggling to calm a wave of online anxiety that has spread to multiple states. But with public trust in mainstream media at a record low, the pipeline from trending content to full-blown conspiracy theory has never been shorter.

More than half of U.S. adults now get their news from social media, according to data from the Pew Research Center, and the voracious demands of the content economy often influence what’s considered newsworthy and how fast stories develop. Over the past month, as authorities have met the growing drone panic with occasional flight restrictions and scant information,

online creators and communities have taken over, rushing to fill in the blanks with theories tailored to followers across the political spectrum.

“Conspiracies appeal to people who feel disenfranchised,” said Jonathan Anzalone, assistant director of the Center for News Literacy at Stony Brook University. “It’s understandable for anyone, regardless of ideology or political affiliation, to feel powerless in a world shaped by forces beyond our control.”

By most accounts, it all began in mid-November when the Asbury Park Press reported that people claimed to have seen large drones flying low in the skies over New Jersey. The Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) tried to allay concerns, saying it had found no evidence of drone activity. But flight restrictions issued in the following days over President-elect Donald Trump’s Bedminster golf course and a local military base fanned the furor.

Since then, purported drone witnesses from Connecticut to Virginia — and as far west as Ohio — have taken to social media to share photos or videos of their sightings, which typically look like faraway orbs or blinking lights. Some have offered rank speculation: Did the government’s lax response to the drone reports indicate that authorities were somehow involved?

“This is the reason the government wants TikTok banned, so

SEE DRONES ON A19

IN THE NEWS

The hunt for Scrim The slippery escapee, a Westie dog mix who has been on the run in New Orleans for weeks, is stealing hearts and inspiring fan art, memes and even tattoos. A8

Fusion power A company plans to build the nation’s first grid-scale plant in Virginia by the early 2030s, Gov. Glenn Youngkin said. B1

THE NATION
Arizona’s top election official suggested predecessors ignored a proof-of-citizenship issue. A3
A Biden administration study could stall Donald Trump’s agenda on liquefied natural gas. A5

THE WORLD
Events in Syria have left Iran exposed, rattling Tehran and uplifting the opposition. A9
A 7.3-magnitude earthquake struck the Pacific island nation of Vanuatu. A13

THE ECONOMY
New rules will require hotels and ticket sellers to display full prices up front, rather than hiding “junk fees.” A18
Nima Momeni was found guilty of murder in the fatal stabbing of Cash App founder Bob Lee, a case that shocked the tech world. A20

THE REGION
The National Building Museum installed a synthetic indoor ice rink that skaters can use until Jan. 4 without the need for outerwear. B1
An FBI informant testified against a former Virginia sheriff accused of deputizing officers in exchange for money. B1

STYLE
Trump sued the Des Moines Register newspaper and its former pollster, escalating his attacks on the media. C1
FOOD
Channel the charm of Christmas across the pond with recipes for prime rib, steamed pudding and sausage rolls. E1

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